

SARAH H. WU

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EDUCATION

PhD in Communication, Stanford University

Concentration: Media Psychology

Sep 2025 –

Stanford, CA

BA in Psychology, Reed College

Phi Beta Kappa

Aug 2019 – May 2023

Portland, OR

Senior Thesis: *The Mind Behind the Music: AI, Intentionality, and the Perception of Musical Narrative*
(advised by Dr. Kevin Holmes)

PUBLICATIONS & PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Papers

- Gomez, M.L., Reich, S.M., Chen, Y.A., **Wu, S.H.**, Cabrera, N. (under review). Reciprocal relationships between parent-child synchrony and parents' use of media to manage behavior.
- **Wu, S.H.**, Yang, Y., Lee, A.Y., Liebscher, A., Rapuano, K., Niederhoffer, K., Hancock, J.T. (2026, July). The role of human agency in human-AI co-creativity. In *Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Creativity and Cognition (C&C '26)*, London, United Kingdom.
- **Wu, S.H.** & Holmes, K.J. (2026). Is there a “mind” behind the music? Attributing music to AI can suppress narrative meaning-making. *Cognitive Research: Principles & Implications*.
- **Wu, S.H.**, Yang, Y., Lee, A.Y., Liebscher, A., Rapuano, K., Niederhoffer, K., Hancock, J.T. (under review). The role of human agency in human-AI co-creativity.
- **Wu, S.H.**, Smith-Russack, Z., Liu, S., Carvalho, G., Lichand, G. Adapting to phone-free schools: Early insights from Brazilian students' perceptions of a nationwide school phone ban. Accepted at the 76th International Communication Association Annual Conference.
- Holmes, K.J., **Wu, S.H.**, Elpers, N., Doherty, E.M., & Flusberg, S.J. (2026). How syntax promotes stereotypes: Assessing the role of pragmatic inference. *Psychonomic Bulletin and Review*.
- **Wu, S.H.** & Corpus, J.H. (2023). The role of perceived cost in college students' motivational experiences and long-term achievement outcomes: A mixed-methods approach. *International Journal of Educational Research Open*, 4, 100229.
- Liu, S., **Wu, S.H.**, Jia, C., Li, J., & Hancock, J.T. (2025). Orientations toward algorithm or human: A systematic review of algorithm aversion, appreciation, ambivalence, and apathy. Presented at the 75th International Communication Association Annual Conference.

Posters

- Lu, J., **Wu, S.H.**, Park, E., Rausch, Z., & Liu, S. (2025, September). Do school phone policies work? Evaluating the effectiveness of school phone policies. Poster presented at the Trust and Safety Research Conference, Stanford, CA.
- **Wu, S. H.**, & Holmes, K. J. (2023, November). Narrative listening and beliefs about human and AI music composers. Poster presented at the 64th Annual Meeting of the Psychonomic Society, San Francisco, CA.

- Schimmel, E., Madar, C. G., **Wu, S. H.**, Shan, L., Waldorf, N., Flusberg, S. J., & Holmes, K. J. (2023, July). Does experiencing an “inner voice” predict language-driven categorical perception? In *Proceedings of the 45th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.
- **Wu, S.H.** & Corpus, J.H. (2023, March) The role of perceived cost in college students’ motivational experiences and long-term achievement outcomes: A mixed-methods approach. Poster presented at the Biennial Meeting of the Society for Research in Child Development, Salt Lake City.
- **Wu, S.H.**, Elpers, N., Doherty, E. M., Flusberg, S.J., & Holmes, K.J. (2021, July). Pragmatic reasoning ability predicts syntactic framing effects on social judgments. Poster presented at the 43rd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society (virtual).

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Predoctoral Research Fellow

July 2024 – Sep 2025

Stanford Social Media Lab

Stanford, CA

- Conducted a systematic review of 150+ recent empirical articles on algorithm aversion, with full paper presented at the International Communication Association conference
- Co-developed the Toolkit for Assessing Phones in Schools (TAPS), a collection of surveys for schools to evaluate the impact of their smartphone policies

Independent Research (Senior Thesis)

Aug 2022 – May 2023

Reed Psychology Dept.

Portland, OR

- Conceived, designed, and executed all aspects of an 8-month independent research project on perceptions of narrative structure in music
- Designed Qualtrics surveys to collect data from 200 Amazon MTurk participants, analyzed the resulting data in R
- Thesis resulted in 50-page paper (including extensive literature review, methods, results and discussion) and oral defense

Research Fellow

Jun – Aug 2022

Reed College Academic Motivation Lab

Portland, OR

- Published paper in *International Journal of Educational Research Open* investigating the psychological costs of college academics for first-year students
- Executed mixed-methods research, analyzing quantitative data using R and thematically analyzing students’ descriptions of their motivational highs and lows

Research Assistant

Jun 2021 – Aug 2021

Reed College Thought Lab

Portland, OR

- Conducted cognitive psychology research on the transmission of stereotypes through syntax
- Created surveys and collected data using Qualtrics, analyzed data from hundreds of participants using R
- Designed a poster and presented the research at CogSci 2021

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Guest Lectures

- “Human Agency in Human-AI Co-Creativity”
Stanford d.school course, How Can Generative AI Help Us Learn? (in-person, May 2026)
- “Starting a PhD Program in the Social Sciences”
Institute for Research in the Social Sciences (in-person, Jan 2026)
- “Psychological Perceptions of AI-Generated Art”
Stanford Summer Session (in-person, August 2025)

- “Psychological Perceptions of AI-Generated Art”
National Chengchi University (virtual, July 2025)

Operations Manager

Aug 2023 – Jun 2024

Peninsula Youth Orchestra (PYO)

San Carlos, CA

- Managed rehearsals, concerts, and Google Classroom content for all 7 PYO ensembles
- Served as the main point of contact for 400+ students, their parents, and staff
- Revamped PYO website in Squarespace to increase engagement, proposed and executed the use of DocuSign to collect forms from current and prospective orchestra members
- Coordinated 100 students and parents for the concert tour of Budapest, Prague, and Vienna
- Secured nearly \$3000 from the Redwood City Arts Commission Grant to support a scholarship for low-income applicants

Teaching Assistant, Cognitive Processes

Jan – May 2023

Reed Psychology Dept.

Portland, OR

- Supported students in an upper-level cognitive psychology course in the conception and execution of 8 lab projects
- Hosted weekly drop-in office hours for students to ask questions about course content and projects
- Provided detailed feedback on students’ scientific writing

Statistics Tutor

Feb – Dec 2021

Reed College

Portland, OR

- Guided introductory statistics students through their homework in individual tutoring sessions
- Empowered students to troubleshoot their coding problems in RStudio

Private Tutor

Jun 2020 – Dec 2022

Self-employed

Remote

- Supplemented distance learning by reading books with 7 elementary and middle school students through one-on-one video calls, asking questions to check for comprehension
- Communicated with parents about their child’s progress

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Assistant Organizer

- Stanford Summer Institute for Computational Social Science (SICSS, planned for summer 2026)

Ad Hoc Reviewer

- *Cognitive Science*
- *Technology, Mind, and Behavior*
- *Empirical Studies of the Arts*
- *International Communication Association*
- *Applied Psychology: Health and Well-Being*

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

Predoctoral Research Fellowship Institute for Research in the Social Sciences, Stanford University	2024
Post-Reed Opportunity Grant Reed College	2023
Phi Beta Kappa Reed College	2023
Opportunity Grant Reed College	2022
Science Research Fellowship Reed College	2022
Commendation for Academic Excellence (x4) Reed College	2020 – 2023
Career Advancement Fund Reed College	2021, 2023
Cognitive Psychology Summer Research Fellowship Reed College	2021
Rothchild Summer Stipend for Music Study Reed College	2022
Jim Kahan Music Performance Summer Fellowship Reed College	2022
Violin Competition Winner Oregon American String Teachers Association	2022

EXTRACURRICULARS

- Perform as a violinist in Orquesta Típica Tarareando, Dome Orchestra, Peninsula Symphony Orchestra
- Perform in small ensembles at interactive musical outreach concerts for elementary and middle schools in the Bay Area